CP HISTORY · WORLD HISTORY I · BENCHMARK 2

Benchmark 2 In-Class DBQ Essay: Empires

Name _____ Section _____

> **Essential question:** How does power expand, and how do states maintain power as they expand?

Instructions

- Write your essay by hand, in class.
- You may use the Benchmark 2 evidence packet. You may not use your journal, notes, or any of your own writing.
- Choose **one** of the two prompts below. You have already seen both and planned your answer.
- Your essay must use at least **four** documents. At least one must be Persian or about Persia, and at least one must be Greek or about Greece.

Choose one prompt

Option 1: What is the relationship between political power and military power in Persia and ancient Greece?

Use Michael Mann's definitions. **Military power** is organized force. **Political power** is the power to govern and make rules over a territory. Does one kind of power create the other, depend on the other, or limit the other?

Option 2: Was Kaplan right?

Robert Kaplan argues that empires offered "the most benign form of order for thousands of years." He says ancient empires "may have been cruel beyond measure, but they were less cruel and delivered more predictability for the average person" than anything beyond their borders. Do the Persian and Athenian empires prove him right, wrong, or partly right?

The evidence packet

Document	Source
Anchor	Robert Kaplan, “In Defense of Empires”
A	The Cyrus Cylinder
B	Herodotus, *Histories*, Book 1
C	Persepolis in 520: the palace reliefs
D	Herodotus, Xerxes’ Bridge
E	Thucydides, the Mytilenean Debate
F	Aeschylus, *The Persians*
G	Thucydides, the Melian Dialogue

Before you write (about 5 minutes)

At the top of your page, jot down your thesis and the documents you plan to use for each paragraph. Then start writing.

Write your essay (about 60 minutes)

Introduction

- Open with one or two sentences of context about the Persian Empire and the Greek city-states.
- End with your thesis.

Body paragraphs (two or three). Build each paragraph in four parts:

1. **Claim:** a topic sentence that supports your thesis.
2. **Evidence:** a quotation or specific detail, with the document labeled, for example (Doc E).
3. **Explain:** how the evidence proves your claim. This is the most important part.
4. **Connect:** link back to the question.

Useful sentence starters:

- “This shows that ___ because ___.”
- “Similarly, in Document ___, ___.”
- “Unlike Persia, Athens ___.”

Source at least two documents. For each one, explain who wrote it, when, or why, and how that affects what it tells us. For example:

- “Because Aeschylus was an Athenian who fought at Salamis, his play ___.”
- “The Cyrus Cylinder was written for Cyrus himself, so ___.”

Counterargument paragraph

- “Some might argue that ___ (Doc ___).”
- “However, this does not hold because ___.”

Conclusion

- Restate your thesis in new words.
- Answer the “so what”: what does this show about how empires gain or keep power?

Check your work (about 5 minutes)

☐ My thesis answers the question I chose.
☐ I used at least four documents, with both Persian and Greek evidence.
☐ I labeled every document I used.
☐ I explained every piece of evidence, not just quoted it.
☐ I sourced at least two documents.
☐ I answered a counterargument.

How you’ll be assessed

Category	What it means in this essay
Mastery of Content	You show accurate knowledge of Persia, Athens, and the key events.
Integration of Evidence	You use at least four documents, accurately and with labels.
Analysis of Content	You explain how evidence proves your claim, source the documents, and answer a counterargument.
Clarity and Organization	You have a clear thesis, organized paragraphs, and a conclusion.
Executive Skills	You plan, manage your time, and finish the essay.